The Cost of the USMLE Route to Match 2027

Every fee an international medical graduate pays, from opening a MyIntealth account to the first day of residency — with three honest budgets

Edition: First edition, August 2026
Fees verified: 18 August 2026 against the ECFMG Fees page (last updated 1 June 2026), the AAMC 2027 ERAS fee schedule, the NRMP Match Fees page, FSMB transcript information, and OET published pricing
Scheduled re-verification: 1 January 2027, when most organisations revise fees
Currency: All figures in United States dollars unless stated

Document Summary

This document sets out the full financial cost of the route from no involvement with the United States medical system to the first day of residency in July 2027. It is written because the figure is nowhere published in one place, because the organisations involved each publish only their own fees, and because applicants routinely begin the process with an estimate that is wrong by several thousand dollars.

- **The unavoidable floor is approximately $6,235** for an applicant testing outside the United States who passes every examination at the first attempt, applies to sixty programmes in one specialty, buys no study materials, undertakes no United States clinical experience, and travels nowhere.
- **A realistic figure for most applicants is around $10,800**, once question banks, one clinical rotation in the United States and a broader programme list are included.
- **A single difficult year reaches $16,000 or more** — one examination retake, one English test retake, two rotations, and applications through both application systems.
- Several fees rose on **1 April 2026** and most published summaries elsewhere still quote the earlier figures. The numbers in this document were taken from the official pages in August 2026.
- The largest controllable costs are, in order: **retakes, United States clinical experience, and the size of the programme list**. Nothing else comes close.

> READ THIS BEFORE BUDGETING
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> Almost every fee described here is **non-refundable**. ERAS states plainly that it issues no refunds for any reason, including applications sent to non-participating programmes. NRMP fees are non-refundable, and fees incurred by certifying a long rank order list are not returned if the list is later shortened. A Pathway application fee is not refunded even where ECFMG determines the applicant was ineligible for the Pathway chosen. The practical implication is that research is not an optional preliminary to spending; it is the cheapest part of the process.

Part One: The Fees, by Organisation

ECFMG — paid through MyIntealth

Fee	Amount	Notes
MyIntealth account establishment	**$110**	Includes a $50 charge for online notarisation of the identification form
Application for ECFMG Certification	**$580**	Paid once
Verification of credentials	**$220**	$110 for the final medical diploma, $110 for the final transcript
Application to a Pathway	**$945**	Non-refundable even if ECFMG finds you ineligible for the Pathway chosen
ERAS token	**$185**	Required to open a MyERAS application
Support for ResidencyCAS application	**$185**	Required for Emergency Medicine and Obstetrics and Gynecology applicants
Application for J-1 visa sponsorship	**$370**	Plus a separate $220 SEVIS fee payable to the Department of Homeland Security
Document translation	**$52 / page**	Charged where a document is not in English and no acceptable translation is supplied
ECFMG Exam History Transcript	**$50**	Per request; non-USMLE examinations only
CVS report to a state medical board	**$70**	Reports to residency programmes are provided at no cost

Source: ECFMG Fees Overview, ecfmg.org/fees, last updated 1 June 2026.

USMLE examinations — paid through FSMB since January 2026

Fee	Amount	Notes
USMLE Step 1, examination fee	**$695**	Registered at usmle.fsmb.org
Step 1 international test delivery surcharge	**$210**	Applies to every testing region other than the United States and Canada
USMLE Step 2 CK, examination fee	**$695**	
Step 2 CK international test delivery surcharge	**$235**	
USMLE Step 3	**~$955**	Not required for certification; requires a valid ECFMG Certificate
FSMB USMLE transcript	**$70**	Once per application cycle; covers transmission to both ERAS and ResidencyCAS
Both required Steps, testing internationally	**$1,835**	**$1,390 if testing in the United States or Canada**

Sources: FSMB USMLE portal fee information and multiple corroborating 2026 summaries; ECFMG directs applicants to usmle.org for current Step fees. Surcharges effective 1 January 2026.

VERIFY BEFORE RELYING ON THESE TWO FIGURES

The ECFMG and NRMP figures in this document were taken directly from those organisations' own fee pages. The Step examination fees and surcharges above are consistent across several independent 2026 sources but were not confirmed on an official page in the same session, because ECFMG now refers applicants to the USMLE and FSMB sites for current pricing. Confirm the Step fees at usmle.org and usmle.fsmb.org before budgeting. Applicants testing in India should also note that an 18 per cent goods and services tax applies.

OET Medicine — paid to OET

Fee	Amount	Notes
Full OET test, four sub-tests	**AUD 587**	Approximately $385. Priced in Australian dollars; the dollar figure moves with the exchange rate
Full OET test, testing in the United States	**$455**	
Rescheduling	**AUD 120–200**	Higher after booking closure

ECFMG requires the minimum score on all four sub-tests **in a single administration**. A shortfall in one sub-test therefore means repeating the whole examination at the full fee; the cheaper single-sub-test option is not available for ECFMG purposes.

Source: OET published pricing and ECFMG Pathways requirements, as reported August 2026. Confirm at oet.com before booking.

AAMC ERAS — the 2027 season rate card

The AAMC introduced a simplified structure for the 2027 season. Two rates apply, both counted **per specialty**, and the count resets with each additional specialty.

Band	Rate	Notes
Programmes 1 to 30 within a specialty	**$11 each**	
Programmes 31 and above within that specialty	**$30 each**	The first thirty remain at $11; only the additional programmes cost $30
USMLE transcript	**$70**	Assessed once per season, via FSMB

The AAMC's own worked example: forty-three Internal Medicine programmes plus seven Radiology programmes comes to $797. Applied to a broad international list, the arithmetic is less comfortable — sixty programmes in a single specialty costs $1,230, of which $900 is attributable to the last thirty.

Source: AAMC, Fees for the 2027 ERAS Season.

> THE RESET IS WORTH UNDERSTANDING
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> Because the count restarts for each specialty, an applicant applying to thirty programmes in each of two specialties pays $660, while an applicant applying to sixty programmes in one specialty pays $1,230 for the same number of applications. This is not an argument for applying to a second specialty you have no interest in — programmes recognise an insincere application — but where a genuine parallel plan exists, the pricing does not penalise it.

ResidencyCAS — Emergency Medicine and Obstetrics and Gynecology

Fee	Amount	Notes
Base application, up to 18 programmes	**$99**	Fees increase for each additional programme; use the official calculator
ECFMG support for ResidencyCAS application	**$185**	Paid to ECFMG, separately from the application fee

Source: ResidencyCAS applicant fee information as summarised by institutional advising pages, August 2026. Confirm the current tier structure with the ResidencyCAS fee calculator.

NRMP — the Match itself

Fee	Amount	Notes
Standard applicant registration	**$85**	Includes up to 20 unique programme codes on the primary rank order list and up to 20 across supplemental lists combined
Extra rank fee	**$30 per code**	For each programme code ranked beyond 20, to a maximum of 300 ranks
Late registration	**$50**	Applies after 29 January 2027
Couples fee	**$45**	Due immediately upon requesting or accepting couple status
Long rank order list fees	**from $50**	Additional fees apply to lists of 100 ranks or more

Source: NRMP Match Fees, nrmp.org. All NRMP fees are non-refundable; extra rank and list-length fees are charged on certification and are not returned if the list is later shortened.

> THE FEE MOST APPLICANTS DO NOT SEE COMING
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> Registration covers twenty ranks. An applicant who interviews well and ranks thirty-five programmes pays a further $450 at the moment of certification — in early March, after every other cost has already been met. Ranking widely remains the right decision, because an unranked programme cannot match you. But the money should be in the account before 3 March 2027.

Part Two: Three Honest Budgets

The tables below build the same journey three times. The fixed component is identical in each; what changes is retakes, clinical experience, and the size of the application effort.

Scenario A — the floor: $6,235

Testing outside the United States. Every examination passed first time. Sixty programmes, one specialty. No study materials purchased, no United States clinical experience, no travel, twelve programmes ranked.

Item	Amount
ENTERING THE SYSTEM	
MyIntealth account establishment	**$110**
Application for ECFMG Certification	**$580**
Verification of credentials	**$220**
EXAMINATIONS	
USMLE Step 1 including surcharge	**$905**
USMLE Step 2 CK including surcharge	**$930**
OET Medicine	**$385**
Application to a Pathway	**$945**
APPLYING	
ERAS token	**$185**
FSMB USMLE transcript	**$70**
ERAS applications, 60 programmes in one specialty	**$1,230**
NRMP standard registration	**$85**
AFTER MATCHING	
J-1 visa sponsorship	**$370**
SEVIS fee	**$220**
Total	**$6,235**

Scenario B — the realistic case: approximately $10,815

As above, plus question banks and self-assessments, one clinical rotation in the United States, one hundred programmes across two specialties, and twenty-five programmes ranked.

Item	Amount
Fixed fees as in Scenario A, excluding ERAS applications and NRMP ranks	**$4,920**
ERAS applications: 70 programmes in specialty one, 30 in specialty two	**$1,860**
NRMP registration plus 5 ranks beyond 20	**$235**
Question banks and self-assessments (estimate)	**$800**
One United States clinical rotation: fee, flights, accommodation (estimate)	**$3,000**
Total	**$10,815**

Scenario C — a difficult year: approximately $16,100

One Step 2 CK retake, one OET retake, applications through both ERAS and ResidencyCAS, two rotations, thirty programmes ranked.

Item	Amount
Fixed fees as in Scenario A, excluding ERAS applications and NRMP ranks	**$4,920**
ECFMG support for ResidencyCAS application	**$185**
ERAS applications, 70 programmes in one specialty	**$1,530**
ResidencyCAS applications, approximately 40 programmes (estimate)	**$539**
NRMP registration plus 10 ranks beyond 20	**$385**
Step 2 CK retake including surcharge	**$930**
OET retake	**$385**
Question banks, self-assessments and courses (estimate)	**$1,200**
Two United States clinical rotations (estimate)	**$6,000**
Total	**~$16,074**

Figures marked as estimates vary enormously by country, provider and personal circumstance and are offered as planning anchors rather than as prices. All other figures are the published fees set out in Part One.

Part Three: Where the Money Is Actually Controllable

What you cannot change

Roughly $2,900 of the total is fixed regardless of how the year goes: the MyIntealth account, the certification application, credential verification, the Pathway application, the ERAS token, the transcript fee and NRMP registration. No strategy reduces these. They should be treated as the entry price and budgeted before anything else is planned.

What you can change, in order of impact

1. **Retakes.** A single Step retake adds $930 when testing internationally, and an OET retake adds $385. More significantly, a failed attempt is visible to programmes for the rest of your career and narrows the programme list you can realistically apply to, which raises costs again. Sitting an examination before you are ready is the most expensive decision available to you, and the expense is not principally financial.
2. **Where you test.** The international surcharges total $445 across both Steps. An applicant with a legitimate opportunity to test in the United States or Canada saves that amount, though travel will usually exceed it.
3. **The size and shape of the programme list.** Beyond thirty programmes in a specialty each further application costs $30 rather than $11, and beyond twenty ranks each further rank costs $30. Applying broadly is correct; applying broadly to programmes that do not accept international applicants, do not sponsor visas, or apply a graduation-year limit is expenditure with a known return of zero. An hour spent checking FREIDA and programme websites is worth more per hour than almost anything else in this process.
4. **Translation.** At $52 per page, a lengthy transcript can add several hundred dollars. Where an acceptable English translation can be obtained locally and in accordance with ECFMG requirements, it is worth investigating early.
5. **Timing.** Registering with the NRMP after 29 January 2027 adds $50 for nothing at all.

What is worth paying for

This document is not an argument for spending as little as possible. Two costs consistently repay themselves. The first is adequate preparation for Step 2 CK, because the score is the principal number by which programmes compare applicants and because a retake is more expensive than any question bank. The second is genuine hands-on United States clinical experience, which produces United States letters of recommendation and is among the most frequently reported differentiators between matched and unmatched international applicants. The costs worth questioning are those that promise outcomes: no organisation can guarantee a match, and every requirement in this document can be completed directly with the responsible body at the published fee.

> A NOTE ON PLANNING
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> The costs in this document are not incurred at once. The entry fees fall at the beginning, examination fees across one to two years, application fees in a single concentrated block in September, and the rank and visa fees in the following spring. An applicant who maps the calendar against the figures will find the burden distributed rather than simultaneous — but the September block, at roughly $1,500 to $2,000 in a single month, is the point at which most applicants are caught short.

Official Fee Pages

Organisation	Where the current fees are published
ECFMG (certification, tokens, J-1)	ecfmg.org/fees
USMLE / FSMB (Step examinations, transcripts)	usmle.org · usmle.fsmb.org · fsmb.org
OET Medicine	occupationalenglishtest.org
AAMC ERAS	students-residents.aamc.org — fees for the 2027 ERAS season
ResidencyCAS	residencycas.com — applicant fee calculator
NRMP	nrmp.org/intro-to-the-match/match-fees

VERIFICATION STATEMENT

ECFMG fees were taken from the ECFMG Fees Overview page, last updated 1 June 2026, on 18 August 2026. AAMC ERAS rates were taken from the AAMC 2027 ERAS season fee page. NRMP fees were taken from the NRMP Match Fees page. Step examination fees, OET pricing and ResidencyCAS tiers were corroborated across multiple independent 2026 sources but were not confirmed on the issuing organisation's own page in that session and are flagged accordingly in Part One. Several ECFMG fees increased on 1 April 2026, and summaries published elsewhere frequently still quote the earlier figures. All fees are subject to change without notice and most organisations revise them in January. This edition is scheduled for re-verification on 1 January 2027. Readers who identify an error are invited to report it so that it may be corrected and the correction recorded.